



The Making of a Coupon Commando

“One. Two. Three. Four,” Elizabeth counted out loud as she tossed the deodorants into the shopping cart. They landed with a satisfying *thunk* in the bottom. “How many more coupons do we have?”

A nearby customer couldn’t help but smile at the unbridled enthusiasm of my teenage daughter. For an hour, Elizabeth and I had roamed the aisles of the Venture discount store, matching up coupons with our purchases and leaving the store with 150 dollars worth of merchandise for less than 25 dollars. The store was our battlefield, and we were prepared to fight inflation. We’d entered the store armed with a carefully organized coupon box and the motto “cheap is good, but free is better.” I often used our shopping sprees as real-life math lessons in our homeschooling, but Elizabeth seemed to enjoy the hunt for good deals nearly as much as I did.

That was in the late 1990s, when coupons regularly saved me 30 to 50 percent off my grocery bill and manufacturer refunds easily netted me 100 dollars a month and the majority of my family’s Christmas gifts. Shopping was like a big game, with me hunting to fill our cupboards with cheap or free soap and cereal and opening the mailbox every day to find it stuffed with rebate checks, free product coupons, and refund premiums. The Sunday newspaper, with the thick, glossy coupon inserts, was our key to